

Blue Flag Iris

Iris versicolor

Northern Blue Flag · Larger Blue Flag



QUALITIES

A bold wetland iris 2 to 3 feet tall, with sword-shaped blue-green leaves rising from spreading rhizomes. In late May and June it produces large violet-blue flowers with bright yellow signal patches and dramatic dark veining on each falling petal — the classic iris form, scaled up. Forms colonies in damp soil over time. Rhizomes are toxic if eaten; do not confuse with edible Sweet Flag (*Acorus calamus*).

CARE

Best in moist to wet soil; thrives at the edge of a rain garden, vegetated swale, or pond. Tolerates average garden soil if watered. Full sun to part shade. Hardy to USDA Zone 3. Plant from 1-gallon stock or bare-root rhizome in spring or fall. Divide every 4-5 years to maintain vigor. Slugs occasionally chew young leaves; rarely a serious issue.

HISTORY

Blue flag was widely used among Indigenous peoples of the Great Lakes region, including the Ojibwe and Anishinaabe, as a powerful medicinal — but specifically for external use; the rhizomes contain compounds that are emetic and dermatologically active. The plant appears in ceremonial contexts in some Algonquian traditions. The name *versicolor* ("various-colored") refers to the elaborate yellow-and-purple signal patterning on the falls.

REASON TO BE

Blue flag iris is the visual anchor of a vegetated bioswale or rain garden. Its bold form and early-summer bloom announce the wet zone of a composition. Bumblebees and skipper butterflies work the flowers; the seed pods provide late-season structural interest. In a residential swale conversion (rock to vegetated), three or five clumps of Blue Flag elevate the channel from "grass meadow" to "designed wet garden" without losing any of the ecological function.